and I always had a sense of contentment coming to study there. I had always been pretty good at maths, and enjoyed the history of it and the practical side, making my own machines and so on when I was a boy. By the time I came belatedly to study maths at Melbourne, I was probably to some extent jaded with cryptography and by what the best cryptographers were doing to make money in the Internet boom. My experience with hacking had made the universe seem harder to understand, not easier, and I suppose I wanted to retreat into the realm of pure thinking.

At first, the university felt like a sheltered workshop for mental outpatients. Everything was so tame, and the days were so structured, and everyone was absorbed in a way that made it seem like the real world had somehow been filtered out. It was nobody's fault, of course, but it was hard for me to connect with my fellow students, given the fifteen-year age gap with most of them and everything that I had been through in my twenties. After all the ups and downs I'd suffered – the hurly-burly of the underground and the media attention round the trial – it felt weird suddenly to have become this passive student. But I was determined to master quantum mechanics and pure maths. I wanted very much to learn everything I could from them and suspected they would push me forward. In no time at all I was immersed in the whole history and traditions of physics, Nils Bohr and Heisenberg and Feynman, and I was keen to become a figure in the Mathematics Society, if not in the university.

I remember, during one period, going to the University of New South Wales to do some advanced maths courses. It was a good time, and I had got back in touch with my real father – I'll write more about that in a minute – and was riding on my bike every day to the university. One day, as I was turning a corner on my bike, a truck suddenly appeared and swiped me into the gutter. I smashed my arm in six places. I was picked up and taken to hospital, where they put my arm in plaster. They also gave me Tramadol, which had a strange and interesting effect. It's a synthetic opiate, and, though it didn't interfere with the clarity of my thought, it removed all negative emotion, including every experience of what you might call psychological pain. So, during a conversation, for instance, I would experience all the positive parts of the conversation but not the negative parts. I went to a class and was aware that my heart rate was up. And all my calibrations were off: the way I placed my foot down to take a step was off,